BLACK WIDOW



Soviet spy turned super heroine Natasha Romanov—a.k.a. the Black Widow—has been an enduring and deadly character since she first appeared in Tales to Astonish #52 in 1964. The Stan Lee, Don Heck, and Don Rico character was something outside the norm for the super hero world. "There was something very interesting that Stan did," recalls Ralph Macchio. "There was something different about her—she was sort of a femme fatale. And if I remember correctly in her first appearance she wasn't wearing a costume."

Indeed, it would be several years before Natasha's trademark skintight black outfit appeared. "Eventually, they gave her the butt-ugliest costume ever," recalls Tom Brevoort. "This atrocious gray-purple fishnet outfit with a cape and a little 'W' mask. Basically, John Romita redesigned her head-to-toe—literally head-to-toe, because her hair color changed. She wasn't a redhead at first; she used to have black hair."

But Macchio explains that from the start; "Stan played it with that Cold War spy mystique and he made her work. She is still very much an outsider because she is a Russian, she was a Soviet agent and she gave up on that and came over to our side, but at the same time I still think she had her love of Mother Russia."

"Black Widow seemed like an obvious character that we wanted to introduce in the world somehow," says Jeremy Latcham. "There was something early on in development that we liked the idea she was Russian and Ivan Vanko was Russian. Scarlett [Johansson] is an awesome actress who is beautiful and was willing to jump into it with a hundred percent devotion. She spent countless hours with the stunt guys training, learning how to flip and kick and jump and punch and do the whole thing."

But the style of fighting is unusual for either the comics or the movies. "We combined a lot of different fighting styles," says Jon Favreau, "and the biggest one was Lucha Libre. Which seemed silly to me when they first mentioned that they thought this Mexican wrestling style of fighting would be good. But when you see the acrobatic moves and the flips and the turns and the holds, when you see a woman doing it in the Black Widow costume—and it's not a guy in a sequined cape—and she moves like a cat, there's a freshness to it. And it really felt right."



Art by Adi Granov (left), Bryan Hitch (right).